



“...would not the sight of a single enemy airplane be enough to induce a formidable panic? Normal life would be unable to continue under the constant threat of death and imminent destruction.”

GENERAL GIULIO DOUHET
THE COMMAND OF THE AIR, 1921

IMPORTANT AIRCRAFT

Introduced in 1937, the Seversky P-35 was a vital steppingstone in the development of American fighter technology. It was the first single-seat, all-metal pursuit plane with retractable landing gear and enclosed cockpit to go into service with the US Army Air Corps.



THE SHADOW OF WAR

DURING THE 1920S AND 1930S, AVIATION DEVELOPED INTO A POTENTIALLY DEVASTATING WEAPON THAT WOULD CHANGE THE NATURE OF WAR

THE EXPERIENCE of World War I set in motion an idea that was to have a potent influence on the future of warfare: the notion that wars could be won by air power alone. The appalling casualties endured by the infantry in the long stalemate in the trenches provided a powerful motive for seeking some other way of fighting a war. And the example of aerial bombardment, especially by airships and Gotha bombers on London, suggested what that new way of fighting might be.

In his book *The Command of the Air*, first published in 1921, Italian general Giulio Douhet argued that in future wars, armies and navies would be relevant only as defensive holding forces while large fleets of heavy bombers delivered massive attacks on enemy cities and industrial centers. Since civilian morale would soon crack, the war would end quickly and with relatively little loss of life.

Although Douhet's writings were little known outside his own country, they expressed an attitude shared by many leading figures in military aviation. They included Sir Hugh Trenchard, Britain's chief of air staff, who had commanded the unified bombing force intended to launch a major aerial offensive on Germany in 1919, before peace intervened. Trenchard ensured that the bombing of cities was the central plank in British air strategy between the wars. In the United States,

the most strident propagandist for military air power was General Billy Mitchell, commander of the US air forces in Europe in 1918 and postwar assistant chief of the Army Air Service. To Trenchard and Mitchell, the great appeal of heavy bombing – whether



“IL DUCE”

Italy's fascist dictator Benito Mussolini was keen to identify himself with the modernity and dynamism that aircraft symbolized. This 1933 portrait by Gerardo Dottori flatters the dictator by composing his image of airplanes.

used for destroying cities or, as Mitchell advocated, to sink enemy ships approaching America's shores – was that it provided a rationale for a powerful air force, independent of, and with equal status to, the other armed services. Trenchard was fortunate in already having the world's only independent air force, the RAF, although in the 1920s he could not secure it more than the most meager funding. Mitchell had to go out and campaign for the force that he felt destined to lead. It was a campaign that brought him into political entanglements and a

conflict with his superiors that eventually led to his court-martial for insubordination in 1925.

Disappearing funds

The pressing problem for military aviation in the immediate postwar period was to persuade tight-fisted governments to fund it adequately. The US air service contracted from 190,000 men in 1918 to 10,000 in 1920; the RAF shrank from a force of almost 300,000 to under 40,000 in the year after the war. The French, worried about Germany, kept a larger air arm – enabling Trenchard to use the “threat” of French aerial strength as an argument for building up the RAF in the 1920s.

In the postwar period, the RAF had a chance to practice the use of air power in a series of small-scale

LUFTWAFFE FLYPAST

In an ominous show of strength, a formation of German Dornier Do 17 bombers fly over a Tag der Wehrmacht rally in 1938. Germany's Nazi regime took every opportunity to show off its bomber force, seeking to intimidate Britain and France with the threat of aerial destruction.